

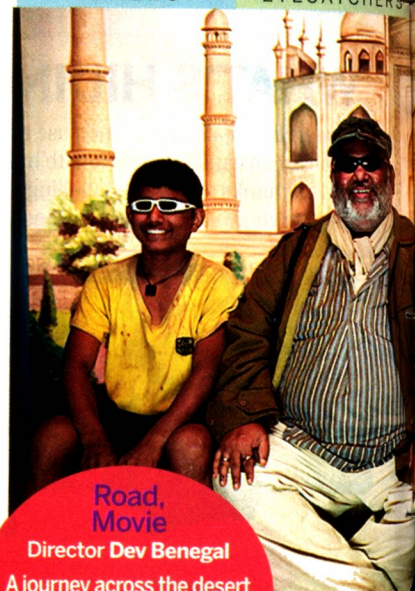
Little Big TRIUMPHS

Cross-dressing documentary directors. Stars defecating onscreen. Farmers committing suicide to claim compensation. A new generation of filmmakers breaks the rules at the Berlin Film Festival.

| By Kaveree Bamzai in Berlin |

At the 60th Berlinale, the loudest cheers were reserved for *My Name is Khan*, from the epiglottis. But there were eight other Indian films, six of them mint fresh, that won applause for their courage. None more so than an absurdist drama centred around the mythical village of Peepli in the state of Mukhya Pradesh, that mocks not only contemporary Indian politics but also TRP-chasing TV channels. Directed by former TV news producer Anusha Rizvi, 34, and produced by actor Aamir Khan, *Peepli Live* is both hilarious and tragic as it traces the attempt of one dispossessed farmer, Natha, to commit suicide so his family can claim the Rs 1 lakh compensation due to victims' families and save their auctioned farm. Shot in the village of Badwai in Madhya Pradesh over 64 days in one go and made in collaboration with 5,000 villagers, many of whom played minor characters and many of whose old clothes were borrowed by the actors, the Rs 6.5-crore film talks about virtually every major contemporary controversy with a light touch. With Raghuraj Yadav in a principal role as

Natha's brother and Naseeruddin Shah in a special appearance as an oily minister who thinks he's suave, it has characters who are easily recognisable and so doubly funny. The female star anchor on first name terms with all politicians, the Hindi news star who is chummy with politicians from the heartland, the tea-drinking bureaucrat who refers everything to the High Court, the politician who is jealous because the star anchor went to "Jaitley's party" and the caste-playing politician who wants to win an election at all costs. At one point, Natha's family has a "Lal Bahadur", a handpump given under a scheme named after the former prime minister, and a TV gifted by a rival politician, but no food to eat. The bureaucrats, as they wait for Natha to commit suicide, scratch their heads, trying to offer him an "Indira Awas", which is only for the homeless and a "Jawahar Rozgar", which is only for the jobless, until they discover that government schemes cover farmers only when they die. There is a happy ending to the movie off-screen though—at the end of the shoot, the producers built a road for the villagers, who gave them a whacky song on inflation in return.



Road, Movie

Director Dev Benegal

A journey across the desert where its star Abhay Deol plays, as usual, a "person on the periphery of society".

